

THE PROMISED GOAL

Computer education in colleges. Is it any good?



MANU KHANNA

India's climb to the peak of Information Technology began in the mid-1980s, when technical and non-technical colleges incorporated computers into their respective curriculum. On one hand were technical colleges that introduced four-year BE/BTech Computer Science and on the other, were non-technical colleges that included it as a subject in addition to Economics, English, etc. However, over time most of these colleges developed loopholes such as obsolete curriculum, poor quality and quantity of computers. This was especially true of non-technical colleges. The result—dissatisfied students, mushrooming of private computer institutes catering to a specific demand and charging exorbitantly for imparting knowledge that doesn't seem worth it on the surface level.

Old isn't gold!

The problems that ail the system of computer education in our country are numer-

ous. Let's start off by taking a closer look at the curriculum or syllabus that is being adhered to by various colleges. In the name of computer software training, students are being taught out-dated languages and that too on out-dated machines.

Broods Naresh, a BE (Mech) student of Vasant Dada Patil College of Engineering, Mumbai, "We are taught BASIC, FORTRAN, etc which is of no use these days. Instead, we should be taught Java or anything else that is in demand today. In a way we are being forced to join computer institutes, like in schools where teachers expect children to come to them for private tuitions if they want to learn more."

Not only is the curriculum obsolete, it's incomplete as well. A BE degree in Computer Science tries to cram in a whole lot of things ranging from algorithms and circuitry to programming languages such as Pascal (apart from the usual BASIC in the first year). This tends to be a non-focussed approach, and only certain universities have the option of different electives and that too in the final year. So, more often than not, you end up learning things that you may not at all be interested in. And while your counterparts in the US may be learning about the latest technology being used by the Intels and the AMDs, here in India, students are being made to do with 8085, 8086 and very rarely, a 486.

Now circuit design is hardly a subject you would find covered by private training institutes, and so you end up neither here nor there, and more often than not, take the usual path of joining a computer institute and learning about other programming languages.

Give me more!

Computers, like Mathematics, is all about practise. The more you practise, the better you become. Theoretical knowledge is important, but without practical knowledge, it amounts to nothing. This is exactly what is happening in most colleges.

Says Kanchan, a student of a New Bombay based engineering college, "For almost one full semester, our computer science teacher made us memorise complex Unix commands, but we

Illustration: Mahesh Benkar

